



K12 AI Coalition | Southeast Wisconsin

AI SPARK WORKBOOK

RUSD AI Sparks David Venne

Five distinct initiatives, each in a two-page snapshot.
The foundation is an innovation enabler; AI use is not documented.

Prepared By: David Venne
Source: September 14, 2026 update



RUSD AI Spark inventory

Five Sparks driving AI, innovation, and new opportunities for RUSD students and staff.

#	INITIATIVE	CATEGORY	REPORTED STATUS	PAGES
01	Hour of AI 4th–6th Grade	Student Success	Delivered Interest reported	03–04
02	District AI Team Policy, learning, rollout	Institutional Innovation	Active team Rollout beginning	05–06
03	NOVA Academy Grades 6–7 microschool	Student Success	Launching 26 active students	07–08
04	JA STEAM Girls AI in hands-on STEAM	Student Success	Reimagined with 40 current students	09–10
05	Racine Unified School Foundation (RUSF)	Institutional Innovation	Newly launched foundation	11–12

Hour of AI | 4th–6th Grade

Student Success

ORGANIZATION

RUSD
Grades 4–6

CONTACT SOURCE

David Venne
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DATE IMPLEMENTED

Winter/Spring 2026

STATUS

Delivered
Across RUSD

THE CHALLENGE

Give students hands-on experiences to explore AI, understand its possibilities and limitations, and use it as a tool for learning, creating, and solving problems.

THE SOLUTION

Students explored AI through hands-on experiences designed to help them learn, analyze information, brainstorm ideas, and understand how AI can support their work. RUSD staff experienced the learning alongside students, building a shared understanding of AI and its possibilities.

AI TOOLS & PLATFORMS USED

Unplugged AI challenges, including custom prompts, lock boxes, and puzzles, gave students a hands-on way to explore how AI works without needing a device.

Hour of AI | 4th–6th Grade

Student Success

WHO BENEFITS

RUSD students in grades 4–6, with more than 100 staff involved.

OUTCOMES & IMPACT — REACH AND REPLICATION INTEREST

>1,500

students participated

>100

staff involved

Shared

Burlington Area School District Library

RESPONSIBLE AI CONSIDERATIONS

Students learned to approach AI with curiosity, responsibility, and a human-centered mindset, with an emphasis on using AI safely and thoughtfully.

WHAT'S NEXT

Continue and refine Hour of AI for 2026–27, using lessons from the first RUSD-wide experience. Burlington Area School District has reached out to learn the model.

District AI Team

Institutional Innovation

ORGANIZATION

RUSD
District-wide

CONTACT SOURCE

David Venne
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DATE IMPLEMENTED

August 2026
Staff training

STATUS

Active team
Student rollout

THE CHALLENGE

Build a district-wide culture of responsible AI use, giving educators the knowledge and tools to work smarter and enhance what they already do.

THE SOLUTION

RUSD moved from conversation to action, developing a Board-approved AI policy and bringing AI learning to more than 1,500 K-12 educators in August 2026.

AI TOOLS & PLATFORMS USED

Staff learning combined hands-on exploration of Gemini and NotebookLM with practical learning around prompting, AI ethics, bias, and responsible use.

District AI Team

Institutional Innovation

WHO BENEFITS

More than 1,500 K-12 educators engaged in AI professional learning, establishing a shared foundation across the district. Student AI learning is now expanding through academy courses and library programming.

OUTCOMES & IMPACT — PARTICIPATION AND DISTRICT MILESTONES

1,500+

K-12 staff trained

Approved

Board-approved policy

Starting

student AI rollout

RESPONSIBLE AI CONSIDERATIONS

A Board-approved AI policy and district-wide learning have created a foundation for responsible, human-centered AI adoption across RUSD.

WHAT'S NEXT

The next phase brings AI directly into student learning through academy courses and library programming, informed by ongoing learning from regional and national leaders.

NOVA Academy

Student Success

ORGANIZATION

Red Apple
RUSD | Grades 6–7

CONTACT SOURCE

David Venne
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DATE IMPLEMENTED

August, 2026

STATUS

Currently Active

THE CHALLENGE

Reimagine learning for grades 6–7 by putting students at the center through personalized learning, meaningful choice, hands-on experiences, and real-world problem solving.

THE SOLUTION

Mornings: Personalized core instruction.

Afternoons: Hands-on workshops, projects, and real-world problem solving.

AI TOOLS & PLATFORMS USED

A connected learning ecosystem using AI and adaptive platforms to personalize learning, target skills, and support student growth.
Featuring Khan Academy & Khanmigo, IXL, Third Space, and Amira.

WHO BENEFITS

Grades 6–7 at Red Apple | 27 students | A potential model for expanding personalized, AI-supported learning across RUSD

OUTCOMES & IMPACT — EARLY PARENT FEEDBACK, NOT MEASURED GAINS

Eagerness

school enthusiasm

Confidence

trying, leading, helping

27

Students

RESPONSIBLE AI CONSIDERATIONS

AI supports learning, not replaces it. NOVA emphasizes thoughtful, responsible use of AI while keeping student voice, choice, creativity, and human connection at the center.

WHAT'S NEXT

Expand to additional cohorts, creating opportunities for more students to experience the NOVA model.

JA STEAM Girls

Student Success

ORGANIZATION

RUSD
JA STEAM Girls

CONTACT SOURCE

David Venne
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DATE IMPLEMENTED

Summer 2026
Program revamped

STATUS

Program active
-40 enrolled

THE CHALLENGE

Inspire girls to explore STEAM through hands-on experiences, real-world applications, and connections to careers shaping the future of technology, including AI.

THE SOLUTION

Program revamped in summer 2026 to incorporate emerging technologies, including AI, while maintaining hands-on career exploration.

AI TOOLS & PLATFORMS USED

AI and emerging technologies were added to the program, with participants using tools such as Gemini and NotebookLM, along with hands-on technology including Tinkercad, Cricut, and Code.org.

JA STEAM Girls

Student Success

WHO BENEFITS

The girls benefit from hands-on exposure to emerging technologies, including AI, coding, digital design, and fabrication, while exploring potential STEAM and career pathways. The program is designed to increase student engagement, build technology skills, and help students see themselves in future STEAM careers.

OUTCOMES & IMPACT

40

currently enrolled

Academies of Racine

Preparing students for choosing a pathway in our academy high schools

SC-J Scholarship

The Gateway/SC-J STEM Scholarship completes the journey, giving girls the opportunity to earn a degree at no cost

RESPONSIBLE AI CONSIDERATIONS

Students learn to use AI responsibly by protecting privacy, thinking critically, checking accuracy, recognizing bias, being transparent about AI use, respecting original work, and practicing good digital citizenship.

WHAT'S NEXT

Program reimaged with ~40 girls enrolled, creating a three-year cohort experience from 6th through 8th grade.

Racine Unified School Foundation

Institutional Innovation

ORGANIZATION

RUSD
RUSF · 501(c)(3)

CONTACT SOURCE

David Venne
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DATE IMPLEMENTED

August 2026

STATUS

New foundation

THE CHALLENGE

Expand innovative programs and student experiences beyond what the traditional school budget can provide. Microsoft engaged as an advisor on the importance of a foundation.

THE SOLUTION

A new 501(c)(3) foundation connects community and business partners with opportunities to directly support RUSD students, schools, and innovative programs.

GOAL AND VISION OF FOUNDATION

RUSF connects the strength of our community with the needs and possibilities of our schools, creating opportunities, experiences, and resources that go beyond what traditional school funding can provide.

Racine Unified School Foundation

Institutional Innovation

WHO BENEFITS

RUSF creates opportunities that benefit students, empower educators, strengthen schools, and connect RUSD with the businesses and community partners who believe in the future of Racine.

OUTCOMES & IMPACT – STATUS ONLY; DEMONSTRATED IMPACT NOT REPORTED

New

501(c)(3) established
Foundation launched

\$50K

Community Funding

District Wide

Opportunities across RUSD
Students – Staff – Schools

RESPONSIBLE AI CONSIDERATIONS

AI should expand opportunity, not replace human judgment. As RUSF considers technology-focused initiatives, investments should align with RUSD AI guidelines, protect student and staff data, and include appropriate human oversight.

WHAT'S NEXT

Build the foundation. Build the partnerships. Build the impact. Establish funding priorities, develop community and business partnerships, launch initial opportunities, and create a process to measure and communicate impact.